1841, a combined Tibetan and Chinese force killed Zorawar Singh and 4,000 of his men near Lake Mansarovar in the Battle of To-Yo. A shrine constructed in his memory, by his enemies, still attracts tourists. Zorawar Singh's foray into Tibet shook the delusions of omnipotence that the Daoguang Emperor of China enjoyed. The mighty Chinese Army had been humbled by the valour of Gen. Zorawar Singh's forces. If the Dogra logistics had not failed him, the entire area around Mount Kailash, replete with water bodies, would have been a rightful part of India.[9]

Around the same time, the Daoguang Emperor's army was defeated in Nanjing, the imperial capital, by a force of the Indian Army led by Maj. Gen. Hugh Gough. Gough later became Commander-in-Chief of the Indian Army.[10] The Daoguang Emperor was forced to sign the Treaty of Nanjing in August 1842, which ended the First Opium War.

Barely a month later, on 17 September 1842, the Qing Emperor of China and the then Dalai Lama of Tibet signed the Treaty of Chushul, with Gulab Singh as a representative of the Sikh Empire, restoring the boundaries of the Sikh Empire to Aksai Chin, a desert plateau between the Karakoram and Kunlun mountain ranges in southern Sinkiang.[11] Gulab Singh was also granted a *jagir* of three villages near Mansarovar. These had originally belonged to the deposed Maharaja of Ladakh. This somewhat ambiguous treaty, drafted in those heady days, would later, in 1949, become the basis of both Indian and Chinese claims to Aksai Chin.[12] In the 1950s, this dispute resulted in the Chinese intrusion into and the annexation of this tract of land.